

Mustelus mustelus

Smooth-hound

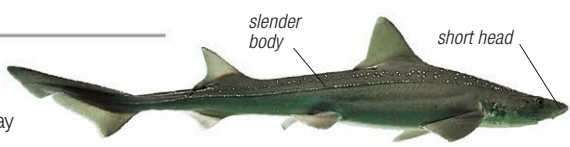


Length Up to 5¼ ft (1.6 m)
Weight 29 lb (13 kg) or more
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location E. Atlantic, Mediterranean



The shiny and relatively smooth skin of the smooth-hound is gray



or gray-brown above and lighter below, with few or no markings. This shark's flat, slab-shaped teeth are designed for crushing mollusks, crabs, lobsters, and other invertebrates, as well as bony fishes. It often feeds in schools. Active after dark, the smooth-hound generally swims near the sea bed in coastal waters, including the intertidal zone. One of nearly 30 similar species worldwide, this shark is commercially fished around Europe, the Mediterranean, and West Africa.

Triakis semifasciata

Leopard shark

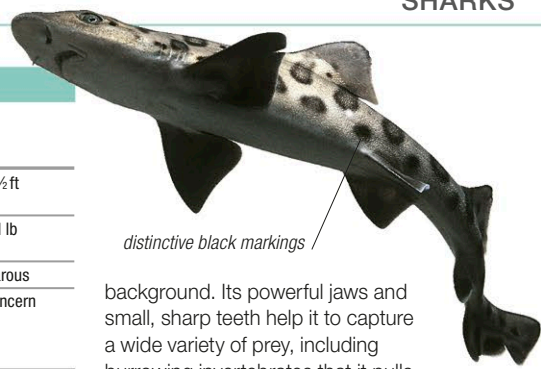


Length Up to 6½ ft (2 m)
Weight Up to 71 lb (32 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Least concern

Location E. North Pacific



The leopard shark is distinguished by a pattern of conspicuous black markings on its sides and fins, over a light brown



distinctive black markings

background. Its powerful jaws and small, sharp teeth help it to capture a wide variety of prey, including burrowing invertebrates that it pulls out by quickly grasping any exposed parts; the shark is thought to feed both by day and by night. There are 4 more similar species but the leopard shark's markings are distinctive.

Cephaloscyllium ventriosum

Swellshark

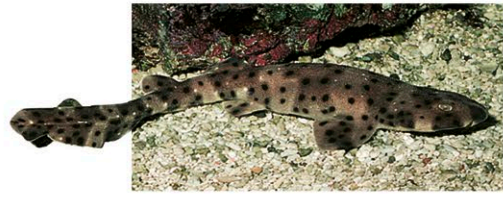


Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight Not recorded
Breeding Oviparous
Status Least concern

Location E. North and South Pacific



When threatened, the swellshark may expand itself by taking in water or air. In addition to making it appear more imposing to potential predators, this defensive technique allows the shark to wedge itself tightly into crevices for safety. This large member of the catshark family has a variable pattern of small spots and dark brown markings. Highly nocturnal, it usually lies motionless in crevices by day, and swims slowly through algae beds or near the seabed at night, presumably preying on diurnal fishes that are less alert at night. The swellshark is one of about 8 similar species.



Scyliorhinus canicula

Small-spotted catshark

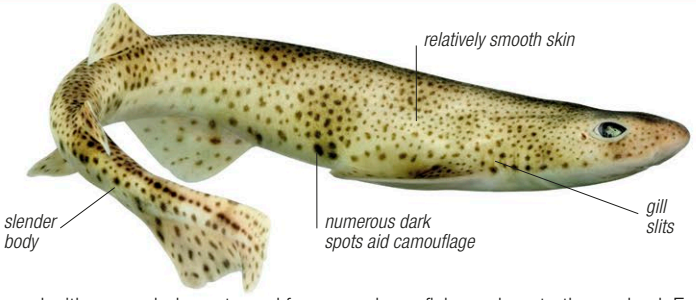


Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight 6½ lb (3 kg) or more
Breeding Oviparous
Status Least concern

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean



Also called the lesser spotted dogfish, this is the commonest European shark. It is small and slender, with a smooth skin



covered with many dark spots and fewer light or white ones. The colors and patterns vary greatly, and help conceal this shark from predatory fishes. Normally solitary, when it does form schools, males and females are rarely found together. This shark is active by both day and night, hunting by scent and electrical sense for worms, mollusks, crustaceans, and small

bony fishes, close to the seabed. Females deposit egg capsules on beds of algae; these are often washed up on the shore and are commonly known as mermaid's purses. They are rectangular, with tendrils at each corner that anchor them to the seaweed. In Europe, the small-spotted catshark is commercially fished for its oily liver as well as for food.

Carcharhinus leucas

Bull shark

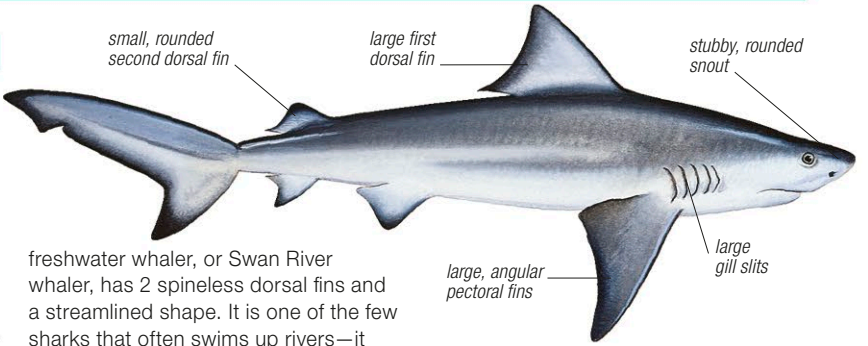


Length Up to 11 ft (3.4 m)
Weight 510 lb (230 kg) or more
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Tropical and subtropical waters worldwide



Like all members of the extensive requiem shark family, the bull shark, also known as the river whaler,

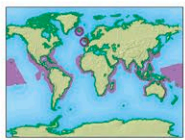


freshwater whaler, or Swan River whaler, has 2 spineless dorsal fins and a streamlined shape. It is one of the few sharks that often swims up rivers—it has been found more than 1,870 miles (3,000 km) from the sea in the Amazon. Its diet is unusually wide-ranging and includes bony fishes, invertebrates, mammals, and other sharks, including

young bull sharks. One of the world's most dangerous sharks, the bull shark has been involved in numerous provoked and unprovoked attacks on humans.

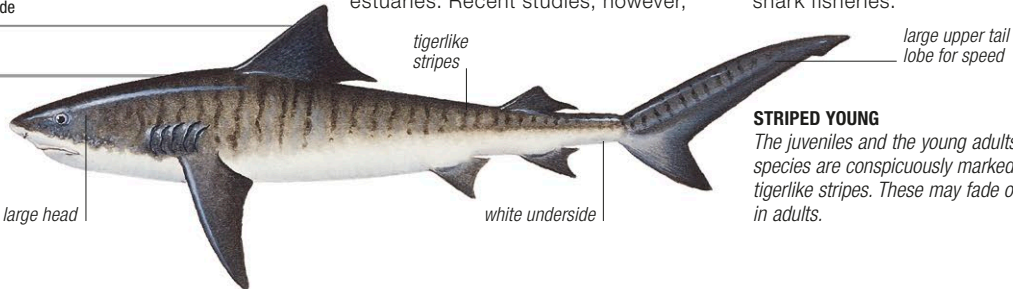
Galeocerdo cuvier

Tiger shark



Length 18–25 ft (5.5–7.5 m)
Weight 1,990 lb (900 kg) or more
Breeding Viviparous
Status Near threatened

Location Tropical and warm temperate waters worldwide



A known man-eater and one of the world's most dangerous sharks, the tiger shark has distinctive teeth shaped like a cockerel's comb, and a head that is disproportionately large for its slender, streamlined body. This shark generally prefers coastal waters, often moving inshore to feed at night, and sometimes exploring the very shallow waters of bays and estuaries. Recent studies, however,

indicate that it may also cross large expanses of open ocean. It makes forays from the tropics to higher latitudes during the warmer months. The tiger shark gives birth to fully developed young; females may secrete uterine "milk" to provide additional nutrition for the embryos. Although not highly valued for its flesh, it is often harvested in commercial shark fisheries.

STRIPED YOUNG
The juveniles and the young adults of this species are conspicuously marked with vertical, tigerlike stripes. These may fade or be absent in adults.

EATING HABITS



A primarily nocturnal hunter, the tiger shark has the most indiscriminate diet among sharks: it employs quick bursts of speed to catch live prey, such as fishes and a variety of marine reptiles, invertebrates, and mammals. It also scavenges on carrion, and may even feed on garbage.